PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS DOCUMENT

Instamart Flatmate Cart

One shared grocery cart per flat, with each flatmate paying their own share at checkout.

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Summary

Flatmates in Indian metros share a kitchen but not a grocery app. Today each person places their own small Instamart order, or one person pays for everything and chases the others for money. **Flatmate Cart** lets a household build one shared cart. Everyone adds their own items, and each person pays for exactly what is theirs through UPI at checkout. One delivery, one fee, no follow-up.

1 order
instead of 2–4 separate small orders per flat

₹0
to chase afterwards: each person pays their own share at checkout

Bigger baskets
more orders per dark store, the lever Instamart needs most

Why now

Instamart is growing fast but is still losing money, and it is behind Blinkit on both scale and profit. In the quarter ending September 2026 it delivered about 130 million orders to 14.8 million monthly transacting users, with an adjusted EBITDA loss of ₹895 crore. In the same quarter Blinkit was profitable and ran more than twice as many dark stores.

Dark stores in mature metros are estimated to break even at around 1,200 to 1,250 orders per store per day. Instamart improves its economics by filling each delivery with more items, not just by adding more orders. A shared household cart turns several small baskets into one larger basket per delivery.

The bet: Shared living is common among young professionals in Bengaluru, Pune, Hyderabad and Gurugram, and that is also where Instamart's dark stores are concentrated. Merging a flat's orders raises basket size without raising discounts.

Problem

What happens today

1. **Separate orders.** Each flatmate orders their own items. The flat pays delivery and handling fees more than once, and orders often fall short of free-delivery thresholds.
2. **One person pays.** One flatmate orders for everyone, then works out who owes what on a calculator and sends UPI requests. Shared items like milk or dish soap are where arguments start.
3. **A shared list elsewhere.** The flat keeps a list in WhatsApp or a notes app, and one person copies it into Instamart. Items get missed and there is no record of who wanted what.

What we know vs. what we're assuming

Statement	Status	How we'd check
Group carts with split payment work in grocery delivery elsewhere (Uber Eats launched one in the US).	Known	Public launch coverage
Instacart's family cart does not let members split payment, and users ask for it.	Known	Instacart help centre
Flats with 2–4 people place multiple small Instamart orders a week from the same address.	Assumption	Count distinct accounts ordering to the same address and flat number
Splitting the bill is a real source of friction, not a minor annoyance.	Assumption	8–10 interviews with flatmates; review complaints about splitting
People will pay at checkout instead of settling later.	Assumption	Fake-door test on the cart screen

Who it's for

Persona	Situation	What they need
The organiser Riya, 26, product analyst, flat of 3 in Koramangala	Always ends up placing the order and chasing payments	Stop being the household bank
The adder Arjun, 24, engineer, same flat	Remembers what he needs at 11 pm and doesn't want a separate ₹150 order	Add items to the flat's next order in seconds
The new flatmate Sana, 25, just moved in	Doesn't know the flat's habits or who usually pays	Join easily and see a clear, fair split

Goals and non-goals

Goals

- Combine a household's separate orders into one delivery
- Make each person's share clear and paid at checkout
- Raise average order value without adding discounts

Non-goals (v1)

- A full expense tracker for rent and bills
- Splitting Swiggy food orders (group ordering already exists there)
- Credit or "pay later" between flatmates

Success metrics

Type	Metric	Target (hypothesis)
North star	Weekly active Flatmate Carts that check out	Set after the pilot baseline
Primary	AOV of Flatmate Cart orders vs. the same users' solo orders	+40% or more

Primary	Orders per address per week for pilot flats	Down (fewer, bigger orders) while GOV per address stays flat or rises
Input	Cart creation → first checkout rate	≥ 50%
Input	Share of carts where all members pay within 10 minutes	≥ 85%
Guardrail	Checkout drop-off when a member doesn't pay	No rise vs. solo checkout
Guardrail	Delivery time for group orders	Same as solo orders of equal size

Solution

How it works

1. **Create.** Anyone starts a Flatmate Cart from the cart screen and shares a link or QR code. The cart is tied to one delivery address.
2. **Add.** Each member adds items from their own phone. Every item is labelled with who added it. Any item can be marked *Shared*.
3. **Review.** The cart shows each person's subtotal, their part of shared items, and their part of fees. Shared items and fees are split equally by default and can be edited.
4. **Pay.** The organiser taps *Request payment*. Each member gets a notification and pays their share with one tap on UPI. The order is placed when everyone has paid, or the organiser can pay any remaining shares.
5. **Deliver.** One delivery. The receipt shows each person's items and payment.

Requirements

Priority	Requirement
P0	Create a cart tied to an address; invite by link or QR code; up to 6 members
P0	Item attribution: each item shows who added it; any item can be marked *Shared*
P0	Live per-person subtotals, including shared items and fees
P0	Split payment through UPI collect, with a 10-minute window and a clear status per member
P0	Fallback: the organiser can cover unpaid shares and place the order
P1	Saved household: the same flatmates and address are reused for the next cart
P1	Custom split for shared items (by percentage or by who uses it)
P1	Out-of-stock handling: a refund goes to the person who added the item, not to the organiser
P2	Weekly "flat restock" reminder built from past shared items

Edge cases

- **A member doesn't pay in time.** Their items stay in the cart. The organiser can pay for them or remove them, and the member sees exactly what happened.
- **An item is substituted or out of stock.** The refund or price difference goes only to the person who added it.

- **A coupon applies.** The discount is split in proportion to each person's subtotal, so no one profits from someone else's order.
- **A member leaves the flat.** Any member can remove them. Past receipts stay visible to everyone.

Rollout and experiment

1. **Fake-door test (2 weeks).** A *Split with flatmates* button on the cart screen in Bengaluru measures intent before anything is built.
2. **Pilot (6 weeks).** Build P0, launch in 3 Bengaluru zones with high shared-living density, and compare AOV and orders per address against matched control zones.
3. **Scale.** Expand to Pune, Hyderabad and Gurugram if AOV rises by 25% or more and guardrails hold.

Risks and open questions

Risk	Mitigation
Waiting for everyone to pay slows down an "instant" purchase	A 10-minute window, the organiser can cover remaining shares, and items stay reserved during the wait
Fewer orders per address looks like a drop in order count	Judge the pilot on GOV per address and AOV, not on order count
UPI collect requests feel like spam	Only cart members receive requests, and there is one request per checkout

Open questions: How many Instamart addresses already have more than one ordering account? Do flats prefer to pay at checkout or settle weekly? Should Instamart's Maxxsaver basket threshold apply to the combined cart?

Sources

- Growth vs profitability: Swiggy's tug-of-war, Inc42 (orders, MTUs, EBITDA, dark stores)
- Quick commerce statistics India, ClickPost (store breakeven, Blinkit profitability)
- Uber Eats its way to more grocery share with group ordering, PYMNTS
- Family carts, Instacart Help Center